



BEFORE

Denied civil and political rights, Indians became increasingly disenchanted with British rule in the late 19th century. By the 1920s there was a mass anticolonial movement demanding home rule for India.

GOVERNMENT OF INDIA ACT

The **British Raj** << 352–53 made some limited concessions to Indian civil rights. In 1909 the **Government of India Act** allowed a very small number of Indians to sit on legislative councils, but their responsibilities were minimal.

INDIAN RIGHTS

The **Indian National Congress (INC)** was founded in 1885 by Western-educated Indians campaigning for Indian rights. Although the Congress represented all Indians, its members were mainly Hindu. In 1906 some Muslims broke away from the INC to form the **Muslim League**.

CIVIL DISOBEDIENCE

During the 1920s, under the leadership of **Mahatma Gandhi** << 408–09, the INC demanded Indian independence. In a long campaign of civil disobedience, known as *satyagraha*, Gandhi encouraged the boycotting of British goods, the nonpayment of taxes, and passive or **nonviolent resistance**.

VIOLENT RESISTANCE

Not all Indians used peaceful means to resist British rule. When World War II << 392–405

broke out, many Indians supported Britain's enemies. The Bengali leader, Subhash Chandra Bose, formed the 20,000-strong Indian National Army, which fought alongside Japanese forces.



INDIAN NATIONAL ARMY

The Partition of India

British rule in India ended in 1947 and the subcontinent was partitioned along religious lines to form the Hindu-majority state of India and the Muslim-majority state of Pakistan. Many millions of Muslims and Hindus caught on the wrong side of the border were forced to flee their homes.

After World War I (see pp.372–75), Britain promised India a major role in governing itself, in return for Indian support during the war. In 1919 a further Government of India Act (see BEFORE) was passed. It created an Indian parliament to which Indian ministers could be elected to hold positions of responsibility in departments such as health, education, and agriculture. However, only the wealthiest Indians, who formed a tiny percentage of the population, were allowed to vote for the

parliament, and the British still held the real power, controlling all the other departments. Another act in 1935 allowed more Indians to vote, and the British kept only the most crucial departments—revenue, defense, and foreign affairs. These concessions did not go far enough for independence campaigners (see BEFORE). At the end of World War II, in 1945, the British agreed to hand over full power.

Direct action

As independence drew closer, the leader of the Muslim League, Muhammad Ali Jinnah, started to demand a separate Muslim state. The idea was resisted by Hindus, including

Gandhi, who believed that India should remain united. In response, Jinnah declared August 16, 1946 “Direct Action Day.” On that day Muslims protested all over India to voice their demand for a separate homeland. Tragically, the protest in Calcutta escalated into violent fighting between religious groups, and thousands of people died.

Drawing the line

Lord Mountbatten, the last viceroy of India, saw that the only way for the British to withdraw was to partition India and to transfer power to two governments. Among the major Indian leaders, only Gandhi refused to agree to partition. He even urged Mountbatten to offer Jinnah the premiership of a united India rather than a separate

Constitutional Assembly crowd

A crowd of people gathered outside the Constitutional Assembly in Karachi as the ceremony to symbolize the transfer of power from Britain to Pakistan took place.

During the ceremony, Lord Mountbatten read a message from George VI pledging the support of the British Commonwealth (nations that were formerly part of the British Empire) to Pakistan.

